Graphic Design

Infographics

Summary Notes

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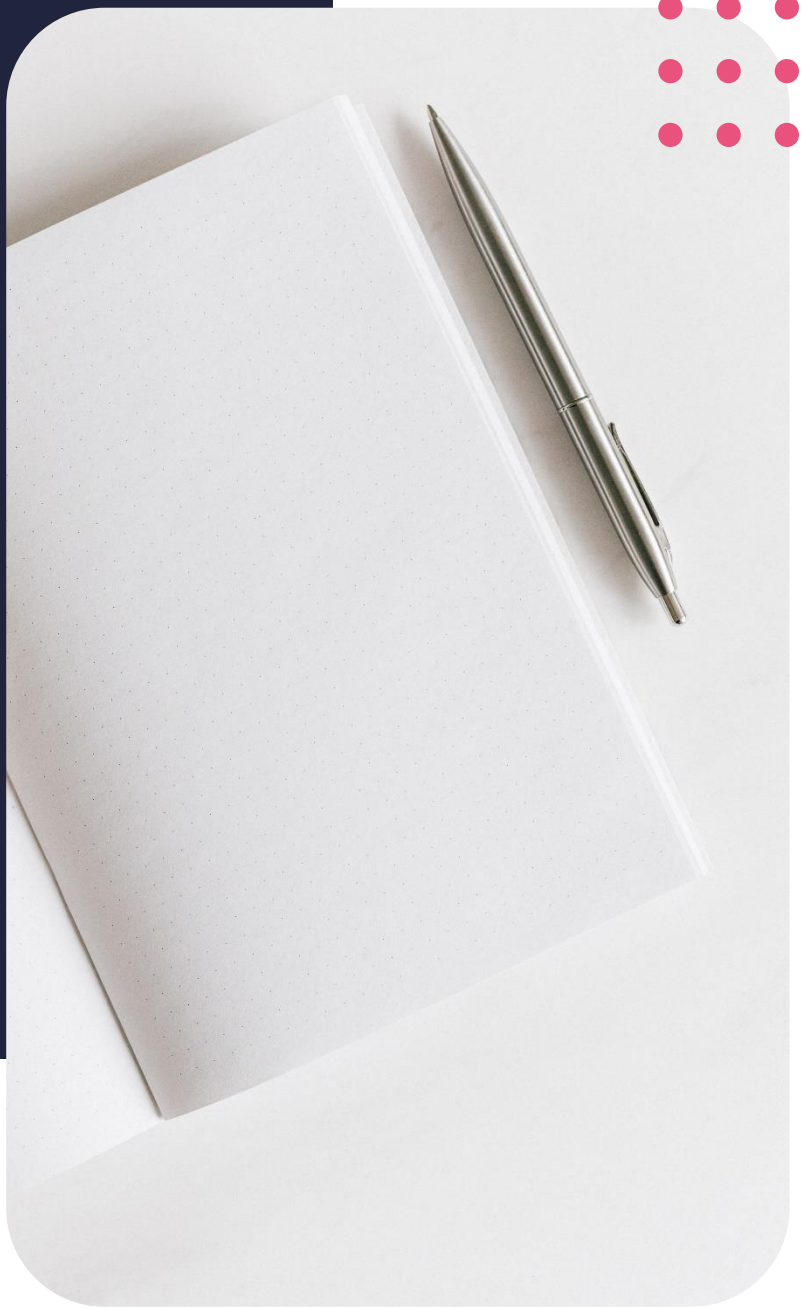


Lesson outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Lesson outcome 1: What is an infographic?
- Lesson outcome 2: When do you need infographics?
- Lesson outcome 3: Infographic types
- Lesson outcome 4: How to create an infographic
- Lesson outcome 5: Infographic demo

Introduction

In case you don't know, infographics are a way to visualise information graphically.

Infographics has become quite a thing recently and even though you might have an idea on what it is, you probably only recently got exposed to it.

The idea of visualising information however is older than you realise. Considering that a map is a visual representation of geographical information, maps have been around for 8 000 odd years. Visualising other information than geography was however rare, since information was rare. Around the 11th century, a chart on how the planets moved in the sky was created by an anonymous scribe.

With a brief history on infographics, I would like to leave you with a quote from 18th century polymath, Joseph Priestly. "A picture conveys information with more exactness, and in much less time than it would take by reading".

In almost every lesson of this course, I emphasised the fact that we, as humans are visual beings and would much rather view things visually than needing to read. I'm not saying that we do not like to read a good book, what I am saying is that it is a lot more effective and quicker to convey information visually.

What is an infographic?

People don't want to take ages to understand visual communication, they want quick, visual methods to assist them as effectively as possible. Infographics are an extremely effective way to visually communicate information to people since it is easier for people to comprehend information in this way than a paragraph of text or descriptive type. We do however get good infographics and we get bad infographics and in today's lesson, we will look at what makes an infographic effective.

All this talk, but what exactly is an infographic? Breaking the word infographic up, the definition is quite simple. An infographic is the visual representation of information, data or knowledge presented in a compelling and appealing graphic format. It is simply information conveyed in a visual manner, mostly making use of graphs, charts, diagrams, and basic illustrations. Infographics can represent a lot of complex data quite quickly.

To ensure that you create effective infographics, always ask yourself the following questions:

Is my infographic well designed? Does it have a theme that it follows, and have you applied the elements and principles of design effectively? All your design elements should be created with unity in mind – there should be consistency in your illustration style, colour scheme as well as typefaces used.

Does it have a story to tell? You need to narrate your infographic and provide information that will offer value to your viewer. Simply creating an infographic for the sake of it, will not be a good idea.

Is it easy to understand? This falls in line with the story your infographic needs to tell. If there's no narrative to follow, how does your viewer know what it's about. Infographics should make the process simpler not more difficult to understand.

When do you need infographics?

Again, simply making an infographic just for the sake of it, or because you feel like it, is not a good way to approach this. Reflect on the following concepts when you are considering creating an infographic.

When you need to communicate quickly. You're at the airport and just in time to check in for your flight. You receive a manual on the locations for each department, however there is no map. The problem here is that you will need to read through the whole manual to know where you will need to check in for your flight. Not only is this not practical, but it will surely take up a lot of unnecessary time. Instead, a visual illustration of the airport will be a lot quicker and more effective.

Imagine being an 8-year-old needing to read the whole user manual on assembling a toy robot without the use of illustrations. Your excitement will not last long if you struggle to assemble to toy. This exact same process can be visually displayed with the help of infographics, making the task at hand effective and convenient for anyone to grasp.

You decide to try out a new recipe. The problem is that it is not in your native tongue and you don't understand Spanish. Having a recipe rather making use of illustrations and measurements, will make the target audience a lot wider than simply typing the recipe out in one language. It will also be quicker to follow.

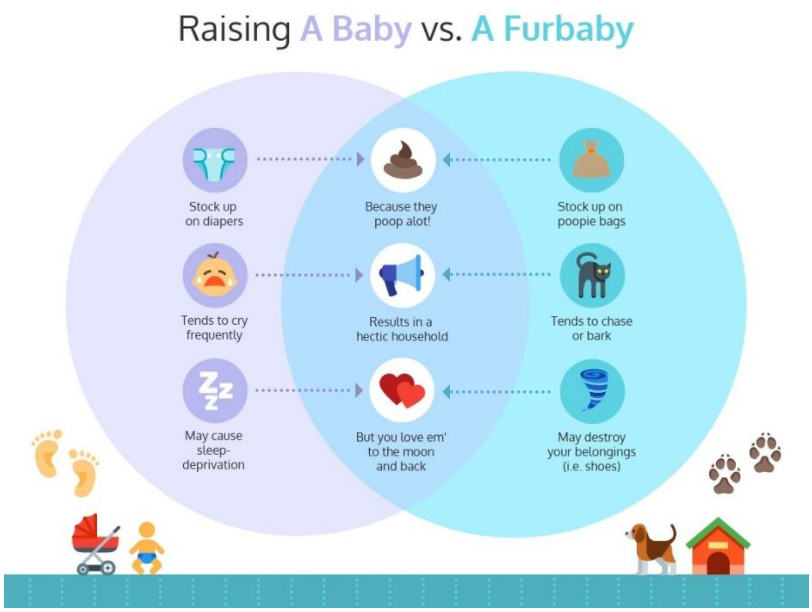
Infographic types

Choosing the type of infographic will depend on the type of information you would like to share. As soon as you get an understanding of the types of infographics we get, it should make your inception process a lot easier.

The list infographic refers to any piece of information that is either in process, list or steps format. This is an example of a list of challenges a company might face with regards to internet security. Other list examples include user manuals or even recipes.

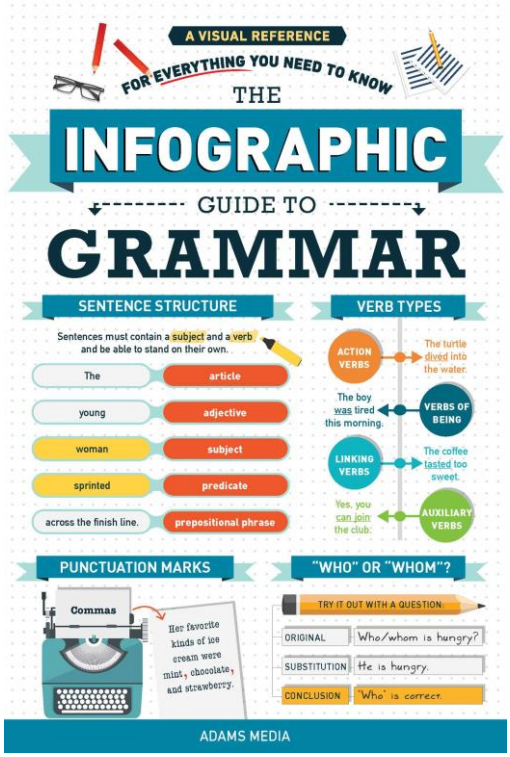
List infographic from: https://venngage.com/templates/infographics/modern-cyber-security-technology-challenges-list-ee76b7b5-e479-4798-ab1a-3d6fd3e2b8cc

A comparison infographic is used to highlight difference between concepts that are similar or to emphasise similarities between two unrelated concepts. Anything that you can make a comparison of basically. The idea of a comparison infographic is to prove that the one concept is either superior or inferior to the other.



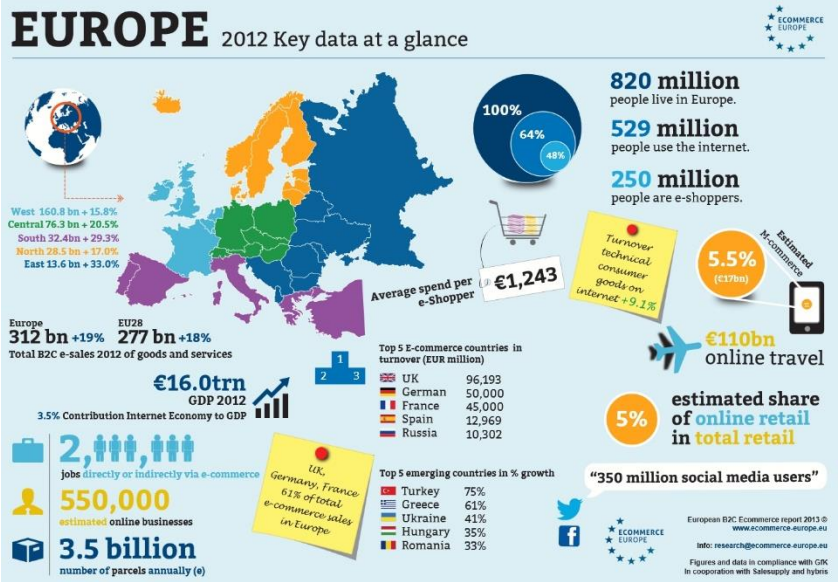
Comparison infographic from: https://venngage.com/blog/6-comparison-infographic-templates/

A visual article or informational article is an infographic used to make information more interesting and enjoyable to view. Classic examples include resumes or company policies.



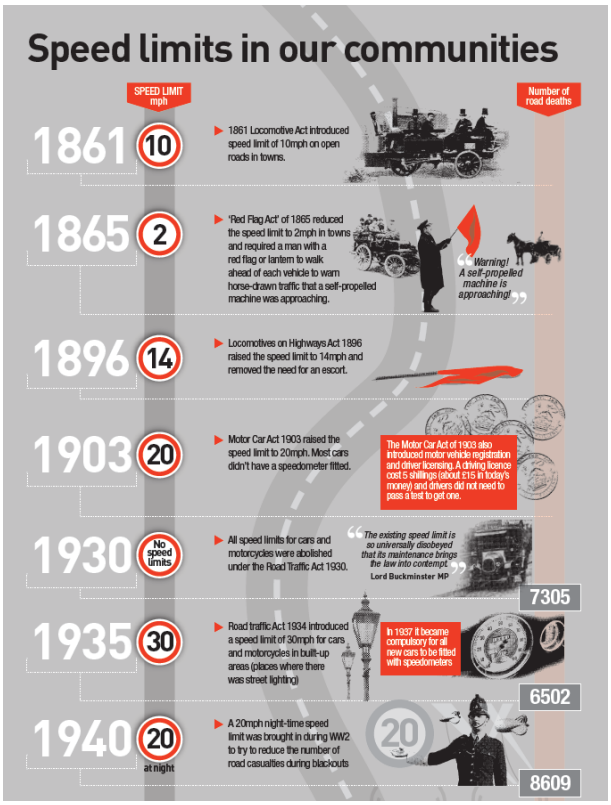
Visual article infographic from: https://www.goodreads.com/book/show/49595116-the-infographic-guide-to-grammar

A geographical or map infographic compare places, culture or people through data and demographics. This example relates to the population and employment of Europe for the year 2012.



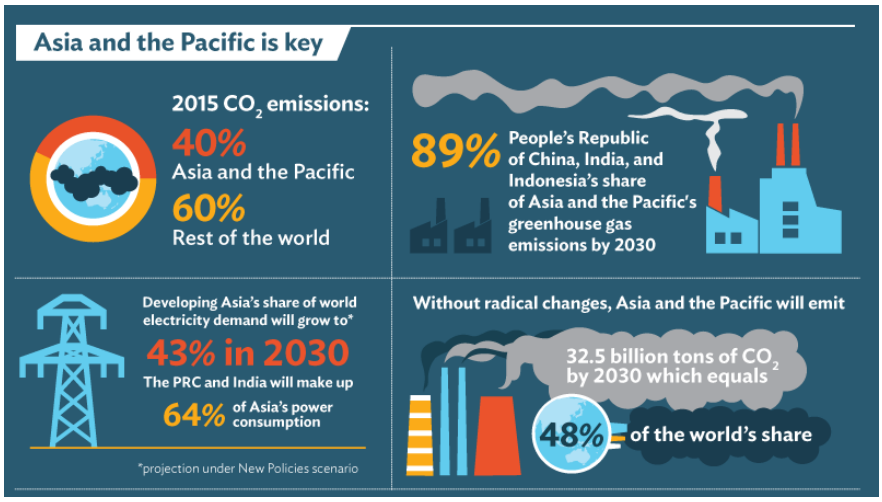
Geographical infographic from: https://ecommercenews.eu/infographic-european-ecommerce-grows-by-19/

A timeline infographic relates to anything that shows progression over a period of time. It shares stories visually through chronological order and make long and complicated events easier to grasp.



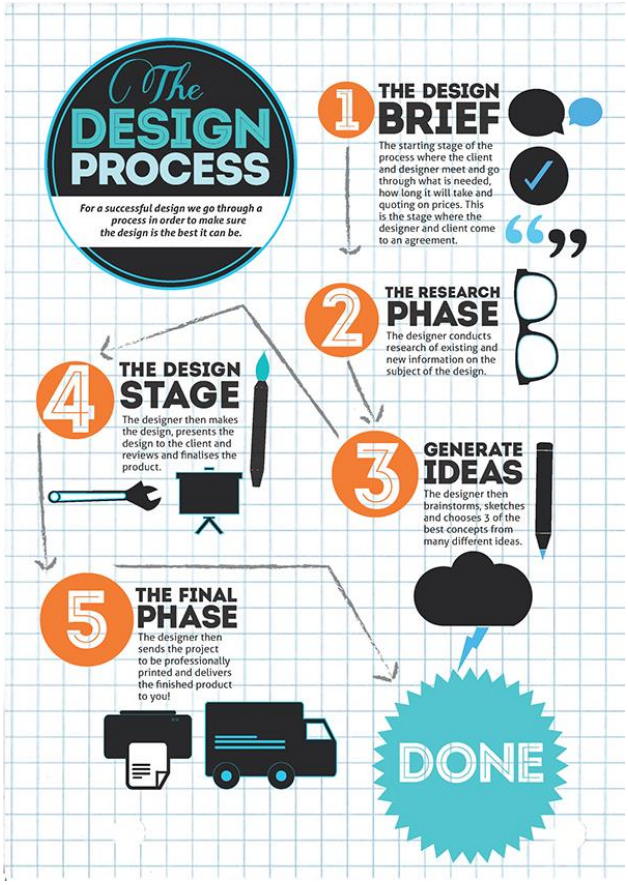
Timeline infographic from: https://brakezebras.org/index.php/factsheets-infographics/item/131-history-of-speed-limits-infographic

A data visualisation or statistical infographic links to any data and research driven arguments. Like the process of global warming and the data collected from this research topic explained with the help of visuals.



Data visualisation infographic from: https://www.adb.org/news/infographics/climate-change-asia-and-pacific

A flow chart can provide personal answers to questions asked and show that multiple situations can reach the same conclusion. An example here would be our design cycle or pipeline infographic we also did in module 1.



Flow chart infographic from: http://www.studentshow.com/gallery/7708175/The-Design-Process-Infographic

How to create an infographic

Before we do our infographic demo, I would like you to make notes on these steps to aid you in creating your own infographic.

I would like to apply a scenario to explain this process. Let's pretend that you have a project to create a design of a company's safety regulations. The safety officer approached you as the graphic designer to come up with a clever way for the company's employees to remember these safety regulations. It is your job as a creative problem solver to make this work.

You will start off by applying your design cycle. Since the safety officer provided you with the content, you must find a good story to tell with this information. First, consider the type of infographic you think will work for this project. In this situation, we can have multiple infographics or even a combination. A list, comparison, visual data, or flow chart might work well for this situation.

Next, take your audience on a journey – make it a ride they will not forget. We all know that safety regulations are not fun and interesting, so, you need to come up with a clever idea to help your audience understand this journey and its importance.

With the journey in mind, you can consider a new angle to inform your audience. Here, your creative thinking skills will come in quite handy. Think about how you, as a designer, can make these safety regulations interesting. Instead of simply listing the process of safety regulations, create a story with this. Ask yourself how you can make this story interesting for people to memorise and remember. Perhaps consider a character that does everything they should not do with regards to safety in the office and build your story around this character.

Having this information in a fun and exciting manner will also thus bring value to your audience since if it weren't for the story and visuals, nobody would have noticed the safety regulations. Adding humour is always a good idea – make sure you understand your target audience, however.

Take the safety regulations and break it down step by step in digestible pieces of information – display this with as little text as possible. Make sure to consider the flow of your infographic as well as where your viewer will start and where they will end – keep the way we read in mind, although, you don't always need to adhere to the f-layout as we learnt in our previous lesson. Just make sure your information is displayed in a logical manner. Make use of a wireframe or grid to guide you here and group information effectively.

Applying the elements and principles of design effectively – make sure you only have one focal point. Also consider that all your elements and principles should speak with one voice and be unified in terms of shape and design – everything should look like they belong together.

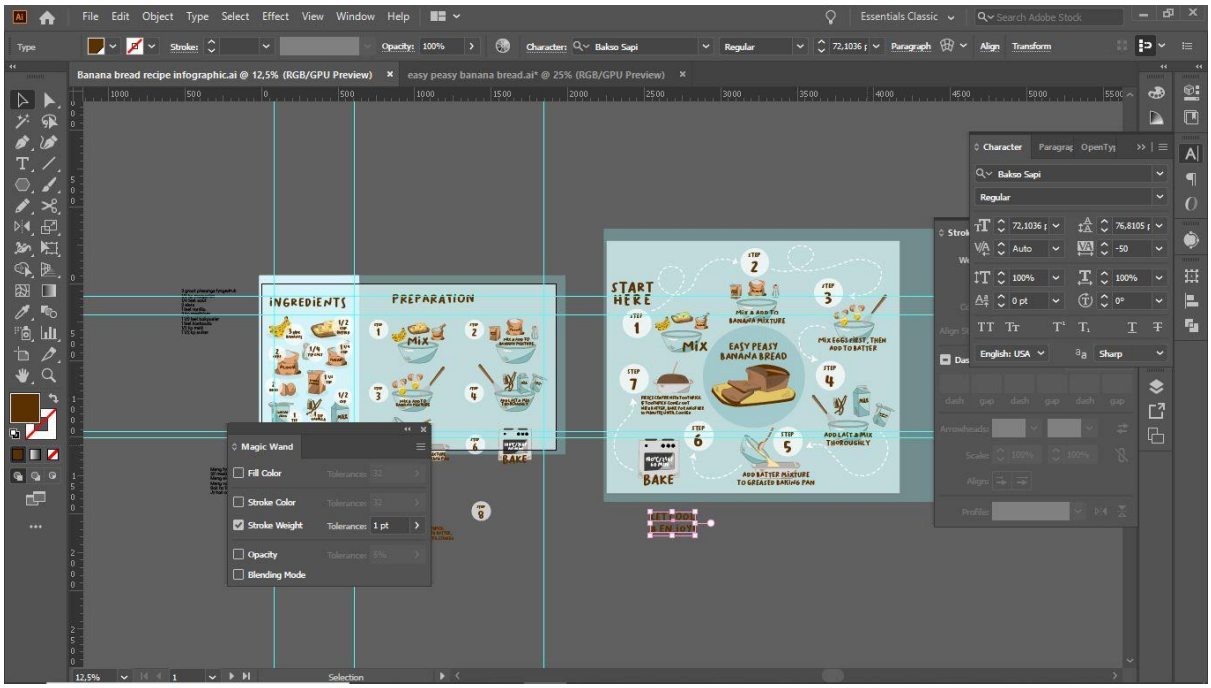
Make use of the colour scheme methods you learnt previously – you can use Adobe's colour library or mood boards. It is a good idea to make use of muted or pastel colours when it comes to infographics. Bright colours can be quite overwhelming. Try and limit your colours to 3 with tints and shades.

Research is the most important part of your infographic and providing only half of the information can misinform your audience. Your information should be as accurate and complete as possible. Also, provide credit where its due – add references at the bottom of your infographic on where you found your information (if necessary).

Lastly, keep it short and to the point. Don't add too much information but also make sure your information is complete. Double check all your facts and spelling and flow issues. Your infographic should take a written piece and show it visually to it's audience – the principle of show, don't tell comes to mind here.

Infographic demo

I hope you have made some notes on creating infographics as we will apply this now in our demo. I will be making use of Illustrator and I will be creating a list infographic to display a banana bread recipe.



Please refer to video demo

Demo – steps to creating an infographic:

1) Gather the information you want to convert to an infographic
2) Read through it and visualise it - create rough sketches of the elements you are able to visualise
3) Summarise the infographic using your visual elements created in step 2
4) Consider your use of colour - trial and error
5) Choose the most effective type of infographic for your information
6) Research images and layouts
7) Create a wireframe/basic layout
8) Start to digitally illustrate your elements
9) Bring everything together

Recipe:

Ingredients:
3 ripe mashed bananas
1/2 cup butter
1/4 teaspoon salt
2 large eggs
1 teaspoon vanilla
2 cups flour
1 1/2 teaspoon baking powder
1 teaspoon baking soda
1/2 cup milk
1 1/2 cup sugar

Preparation:
Mash bananas and mix with sugar and soft butter
Mix flour, baking powder and salt and add to banana mix
Whisk eggs and add to mixture
Mix vanilla, baking soda and milk and add last
Mix everything thoroughly
Bake at 180C until your bread is a golden brown - for about 1 hour. Test with a sharp knife or toothpick by pricking the bread in the centre. If the toothpick comes out clean, your banana bread is baked through. If not, bake for another 10 minutes or until toothpick comes out clean

Recipe translated from: www.keyingredient.com/recipes/13286045/piesangbrood-resepte-vir-die-jongergeslag/

I want you to create your own infographic. You can display your favourite recipe with the aid of visuals or if you have any other type of idea in mind, you're more than welcome to create that.

Share your infographic to your favourite social media platform.

I'm excited to see what you came up with. Remember to ask your friend's colleagues and family whether they understand your infographic to determine its effectiveness.

Conclusion

By now, I'm sure you are quite skilled and might ask yourself what is lined up next? Well, if you think you know a lot about graphic design now, wait till you get a little further.

We will consider the ins and outs of running your own design business as well as other tools that designers can make use of to speed up their everyday workflow. Yes, it is possible to create animation in photoshop in many forms – we will investigate the timeline panel in Photoshop.

We will make use of the skills we learnt so far to create our own infographic resume and I will also teach you some great tips for what to expect at a job interview, specifically as a graphic designer. We will end off by creating your professional digital design portfolio, so that you will be geared for that interview or new client you would like to approach.

In this lesson, we ended off with a remarkably interesting lesson on the ins and outs of infographics. We defined and infographic and discussed the reasoning behind using infographics

The different types of infographics make this process slightly easier when you head on over to create your actual infographic. Our demo entailed the creation of a list or step infographic where we created a recipe.

Thank you so much for sticking around and I'm sure that you enjoy these lessons and have learnt a lot of new skills so far.

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